five companies of 136 Engineer Regiment plus other service elements bringing the total Chinese strength to approximately 22,000 combat troops. 419 Tibetan Unit with 55 Division was to execute the main thrust against Se-la. 11 Division was to advance along the Tse-la–Poshing-la axis and cut off Dirang from Bomdila while part of the force would attack Dirang and cut off the southern escape routes.

On 15 November, the CMAC appointed Marshal Mi Liu as the commander of the attacking force. Speaking to his subordinates, Mi Liu pointed out that victory could be achieved only by determined and relentless pursuit of the stated objectives. The Indians in front were well coordinated—'the head,' he said, 'is like copper and the tail like tin'. Pointing to the Indian defence posture at Se-la and Senge Dzong he said, 'the right side is like the backbone while the left side deployment is like the stomach. The main thrust towards Se-la and Senge Dzong would be like hitting the Indians in the stomach, which should be comparatively easier than trying to break the backbone.'

The Chinese intent of sweeping across the battlefield was clearly visible from the Indian positions on Se-la. The feverish pace with which they were working on building a Class 9 road (capable of taking 3-ton vehicles) that would allow them to link Bum-la to Tawang was obvious from the very outset. The large Tibetan workforce, dressed in blue, was hard to miss.

However, having declared in public that nothing further was likely to happen in Se-la till the next year, Kaul and his Corps HQ had turned their attention towards Walong. Even though so far Indian patrols had met with little success against a mobile enemy that was not necessarily restricted to the available roads and tracks, both 62 Infantry Brigade and 4 Division's HQs should have known that the Chinese infiltration across the Tawang Chu had begun by 11 November. The Chinese 419 Tibetan Unit had been tasked to move up to Mago, using yaks and ponies to push as much equipment and supplies forward. Then the self-contained and superbly fit troops were given clear-cut objectives with a timetable that had to be adhered to. In small and sometimes large groups, these commando style units began to move across some of the most difficult terrain, towing trolley-mounted mortars and RCLs at a blistering pace.

The 419 Tibetan Unit was commanded by General Chai Hong Tuo. He was in his fifties and travelled on a sturdy grey pony with a couple of extra animals so that he could keep pace with his men. The objective of this unit